



How to Build a Community and Why it Matters

Building and sustaining an open source community is certainly not a bed of roses. This article outlines a few important steps you can follow to do so.

The demand for open source communities is growing. Community development is like an adventure in the deep woods. You need to start with a lot of preparation, especially to face the unknown. Technology and tools continue to evolve, so you cannot rely on them completely. On your journey, you will find fellow travellers who support you, but you should be ready to deal with surprises.

Why build a community?

It's often thought that a community is needed to address problems or offer support to people. These are valid reasons, but building a thriving community will entirely depend on you as a leader. There are four common challenges that have to be overcome for people to start or join a community.

Why?: This is an important question that people have, as they feel community contribution yields no returns.

Awareness: There are a lot of communities that need a supporting hand, but there is not much awareness about them.

Where to start?: There are many who do not know where to start, despite wanting to do so.

How to start?: People are unsure of what role they can play and where their contributions can be helpful.

These challenges can be addressed if people realise the wide range of valuable skills they will gain by building and participating in an open source community. These range from exposure to new technology and improved communication skills, to development of strategic thinking and influencing large numbers. To build a

community, it will be helpful to start discussions with volunteers, note down your purpose, explore opportunities, and connect with fellow teammates.

Five steps to help you build a community

1. Research for a common interest:

The very first thing to do is carry out research, which can be done in a day, a week, or a month at the maximum. Do not spend too much time on it. Think of it as a need for a group to be formed, be it technical or non-technical. You can visit two places to figure out whether it would be worth your while to start or not. The first is *Meetup.com*, where there are many communities worldwide, not limited by location or technology. The second place is *Discord*. Even though it was started for gamers, it is